



IFDC RESOURCE • NO. 1

IFDC MEDIA GUIDANCE

GUIDELINES ON RIGHTS-BASED MEDIA COVERAGE OF CHILDREN AND ADOLESCENTS

Ten principles for journalists reporting on children and young people in Sri Lanka

A PUBLICATION OF THE INTERNATIONAL FOUNDATION FOR DIGITAL CHILD
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Journalists shape how the public sees Sri Lanka's children. A rights-based approach to reporting means treating every child not as a passive subject of a story, but as a person with dignity, a voice, and legal protections that follow them into print, broadcast and online. The ten principles below give newsrooms a practical starting point for coverage that informs the public without compromising a child's safety or well-being.

1. Put the Child's Wellbeing First

Every editorial decision involving a child — what to publish, what to hold back, which image to run — should be weighed against that child's interests and safety, not just the strength of the story. Sri Lanka's Children and Young Persons Ordinance and the National Child Protection Authority Act (No. 50 of 1998) both rest on this same idea: the child's welfare takes priority over competing interests, including a newsroom's deadline.

2. Let Children Be Heard, Not Just Described

Wherever it is safe and appropriate to do so, bring in the child's own words, experience and perspective rather than reporting only what adults say about them. A feature on school dropout rates in the estate sector, for instance, is stronger and fairer when it includes what affected students themselves say about their circumstances — always with consent and without exposing them to risk.

3. Give Stories Context, Not Just Incidents

A single case rarely tells the whole story. Ground reporting on children in verified data, research and expert comment so audiences understand scale and pattern rather than being left with an isolated, sensational anecdote. The National Child Protection Authority's 1929 helpline, for example, logged roughly 40 abuse-related complaints a day in 2020 — a statistic that helps readers understand an individual case as part of a wider national pattern rather than a one-off tragedy.

4. Choose Words That Respect, Not Stereotype

Language about children should be accurate, inclusive and free of labels that demean or exclude. Avoid framing that reduces a child to a category — “street child,” “estate child,” “child of a convict” — where that label adds nothing but stigma to the story.

5. Never Let a Child's Origin Become Their Headline

Do not identify or characterise a child by their parentage, guardianship status, ethnicity or family circumstances in a way that could expose them to shame or exclusion — for example, describing a child solely as “the daughter of a suspect in the [X] case” or defining a child by a parent's HIV status, immigration history or criminal record.

6. Support Safe, Meaningful Participation

Children and young people increasingly create and share their own content on social platforms. Newsrooms and media literacy initiatives should encourage this participation while helping young Sri Lankans understand privacy settings, consent and the permanence of what they post.

7. Set Clear Ground Rules Before Any Interview

Before speaking to a child on the record:

- Confirm there is a genuine editorial reason to interview a child rather than an adult, and that the request suits the child's age and maturity.
- Obtain informed consent from the child in language they can understand, and make clear they can stop or withdraw at any point.
- Obtain consent from a parent or legal guardian as well.
- Explain, in age-appropriate terms, how the material will be used, where it will appear, and who will see it.

Good Interview Practice

- Speak plainly and respectfully — avoid a tone that talks down to the child.
- Choose a setting where the child feels safe and unhurried.
- Respect the child's privacy, their sense of self, and their right to decline to answer.

8. Guard Identity and Personal Data Closely

Extra caution is required whenever a child is in a vulnerable or at-risk situation — a victim of abuse, a child in state care, a child in conflict with the law, or a child connected to an ongoing investigation. Do not publish a name, photograph, address, school, or any combination of details that would let readers identify the child, if doing so could put their safety, rights or dignity at risk.

SRI LANKA IN PRACTICE

Section 6.2 of the Editors' Guild of Sri Lanka's Code of Professional Practice, which the Press Complaints Commission of Sri Lanka (PCCSL) enforces through its Dispute Resolution Council, already reflects this principle: publications must not name victims of sex crimes, and must not knowingly identify an accused young person under 16 who has no prior convictions, unless doing so is both legally permitted and in the public interest.

9. Champion Content Made For Children

Beyond news coverage of children, media houses have a role in commissioning and broadcasting age-appropriate content that entertains, informs and reflects Sri Lanka's children back to themselves — across Sinhala, Tamil and English language services.

10. Build Media Literacy Alongside Reporting

Coverage decisions are only half the picture. Newsrooms, schools and organisations such as IFDC also have a role in equipping children and adolescents to read, question and safely navigate the media and digital platforms they encounter every day.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Sri Lanka is party to the UN Convention on the Rights of the Child, and its own Constitution and child protection laws build on the same principle: a child's best interests, privacy and dignity are not optional editorial considerations — they are the baseline for responsible journalism.

Adapted and contextualised by the International Foundation for Digital Child (IFDC) for the Sri Lankan media community, drawing on internationally recognised standards for rights-based reporting on children, including the Editors' Guild of Sri Lanka's Code of Professional Practice as administered by the Press Complaints Commission of Sri Lanka (PCCSL). © IFDC — www.ifdchild.org. Sri Lankan child-protection statistics referenced from the National Child Protection Authority (NCPA).

GET HELP · REPORT A CONCERN · KNOW YOUR RESOURCES

Sri Lankan Bodies Every Journalist Covering Children Should Know

EDITORS' GUILD OF SRI LANKA

No. 96, Kirula Road, Colombo 05, Sri Lanka

Self-regulatory body for editors — Code of Professional Practice

PRESS COMPLAINTS COMMISSION OF SRI LANKA (PCCSL)

96 Bernard Soysa Mawatha (Kirula Road), Colombo 00500

Web: www.pccsl.lk

Independent Dispute Resolution Council for complaints against the press

HUMAN RIGHTS COMMISSION OF SRI LANKA (HRCSL)

No. 14, R. A. De Mel Mawatha, Colombo 04

Tel: 011 250 5580 / 011 250 5581 / 011 250 5582 · Hotline: 1996

Web: www.hrcsl.lk

LEGAL AID COMMISSION OF SRI LANKA

No. 129, Hulftsdorp Street, Colombo 12

Tel: +94 11 243 3618 / +94 11 533 5329 / +94 11 533 5281

Email: legalaids@sltnet.lk · Web: www.legalaids.gov.lk

Free legal advice and court representation for eligible persons, including in child-related matters

NATIONAL CHILD PROTECTION AUTHORITY (NCPA)

No. 330, Thalawathugoda Road, Madiwela, Sri Lanka

Childline: 1929 (toll-free, 24 hours, trilingual) · Tel: +94 11 277 8911–14

Email: ncpa@childprotection.gov.lk · Web: www.childprotection.gov.lk

INTERNATIONAL FOUNDATION FOR DIGITAL CHILD (IFDC)

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